Landmarks & Roles

In short

Screen reader users can jump to parts of a page, like the menu, using landmarks. Roles tell them what each item is, such as a button. Use the right HTML tags, and both are added for you.

What is it for?

Imagine trying to navigate a city with no street signs, where every building looks exactly the same. That is what a website feels like to a screen reader user without Landmarks and Roles.

- Landmarks: These are like zones on a map. They tell the user 'This is the Navigation' or 'This is the Main Content'. They let users jump right to what they want to read.
- Roles: These are like name tags. They tell the user exactly what an item is. A plain box tells the user nothing, but a 'Button' role says, 'Click me!'

It is supported universally. All browsers understand standard HTML tags automatically. It's just a matter of choosing the right ones.

How to support it

The best way is to use semantic HTML (standard HTML tags). When you use the right tag, the landmark or role is added for you automatically.

- Landmarks: Use <nav> for menus and <main> for your main content.
- Roles: Use <button> for buttons and <a> for links.

Making a plain box act like a button

You can use code to force a plain box (`<div>`) to act like a `<button>`, but it is risky, and takes much more work.

- Using a `<button>` tag is like buying a chair. It comes ready to sit on.
- Using a `<div>` is like buying a pile of wood and writing 'Chair' on it. It says it's a chair, but you have to build the legs yourself (for example, add keyboard support) or it will fall apart.

Useful links

- CSS Tricks - Why, How, and When to Use Semantic HTML and Accessible Rich Internet Applications (ARIA)
- HTML Semantics and Accessibility Cheat Sheet
- How to Improve Web Accessibility with Landmarks

Abbreviations

The full form of each abbreviation used in this document.

ARIA: Accessible Rich Internet Applications

CSS: Cascading Style Sheets

HTML: HyperText Markup Language